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Exploring Masculine Stereotypes Through A Queer Lens in Kinetic Novel-Making

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Abstract

Queerness has an established history in screen-based media, be it in film or digital games, yet its representation is often poor in execution, mired with stereotypes, forced tropes or simply weak writing leading to insincere and even problematic depictions of the Queer community. Queer independent game developers champion depicting queer people in order to offer better and more authentic experiences, but even they are not exempt from mistakes, often due to lack of time, resources and funding.

This thesis aims to learn more about the origins of queer stereotypes and queer coding in Western film and how it has impacted modern games, followed by the generation of an original Kinetic Visual Novel as a research-inspired praxis informed by both research as well as the author's personal experiences of his own queer habitus. The aim is to explore subverting players' expectations of visual stereotypes and tropes by actively challenging norms in character design and writing.

As this work is a mix of plaited exegesis with other methods, the results will be reflective of the work the author has done. It will be tied in with information gained from player and stakeholder interviews and reflected upon from a unique perspective of a queer author and artist.

Keywords

plaited exegesis, queer stereotypes, queer games, video games, creative research

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1. Introduction

Queer representation in games has a long history, with examples such as Paco from *Le crime du parking* (Froggy Software, 1985) or Carlus from *Le mur de Berlin va sauter* (Froggy Software, 1985). Despite being early examples of queer characters in games, both are antagonists, and their queerness feels almost like an afterthought. Since then, the number of queer characters in games has increased exponentially, but they are still lacking in quality and complexity at times (Myers, 2025).

This creative research aims to take a general look at the history of queer characters in games and films and briefly analyse the stereotypes surrounding queer representation. By creating a Kinetic Novel (defined later in this research) I wish to observe expectations around the masculine tropes of "Nerd" and "Jock", that are often used in entertainment media. The aim is to subvert the players' expectations of the characters, in masculine and queer sense. As this is a self-reflective work, the aim of this research is to test the limits of my comfort zone surrounding queerness in media, queer stereotypes and tropes, and their place in games. The characters I create are based off my own understanding of various stereotypes and tropes as informed by sources I find (TV tropes; Arltoft and Benkö, 2019; Kilzer, 2022; Myers, 2025; Tagudina, 2012; Koeun, 2017). Therefore, the main question of this thesis will be: How do stereotype visuals influence how we see queer characters, and where do they come from?

As part of the research, I wish to explore how visual stereotypes and tropes can be also used to subvert expectations of the story. Which coding does it well and which one fall flat on their face when readers are presented with it? As part of the reflective work, I will try to adjust my designs through the research process to come to better understanding what works and what does not. Of course, it is important to keep in mind everyone's views are subjective, same with my own, therefore there is no way of "perfecting" it, only doing my best to understand it more than I did before.

1.1 Stereotypes

In this research, I will be using Merriam-Webster Dictionary definition of word "stereotype" meaning "something conforming to a fixed or general pattern; especially: a standardised mental picture that is held in common by members of a group and that represents an oversimplified opinion, prejudiced attitude, or uncritical judgment". I will be using masculine stereotypes of "Nerd" and "Jock" that are recognisable in Western film. With a "nerd" character, viewers often assume they will be "socially awkward", unpopular, and will have interest in "nerdy" hobbies, such as sciences or topics often seen as "unpopular". "Jock" characters can come in various flavours, such as "Lovable Jock", "Dumb Jock", or "Jerk Jock", but all of them fall under "athletic" and "popular" categories. They can be protagonists or antagonists, but most often when paired with a "nerd" character, it will be a "jerk jock" who bullies the nerd (TV Tropes).

The reason for picking these stereotypes is because they have a fairly recognisable visual style. The nerd characters are often described as "unstylish" by wearing outdated or overly proper clothes, alongside glasses. In contrast, a jock character will often wear a "letterman jacket", which is a jacket awarded to students who are part of sports team representing their school, usually seen in United States (TV Tropes).

The topic of queerness in media, especially in films, can easily become too broad for a research topic. I will limit it to analysing specifically Western cinema around the 1900s, as that is when the biggest shift happened due to the introduction of Hays Code as well as films taking over as the main entertainment media. Before the Code, it was more common to see queer representation in media that was even positive, but the introduction of it really shifted how media portrayed queerness to a more negative view. (Ward, 2020)

1.2 Visual Novels

For this research paper I will be making a queer Kinetic Novel where I will try to explore stereotypes of “Nerd” and “Jock” through queer lens and how they can be used to subvert players’ expectations. The reason for picking a visual novel over other types of games is due to accessibility of working alone on this project, as well as wanting to focus more on the art and the designs over the mechanics. Visual Novels are also known to utilise archetypes in their stories for storytelling purposes, which will be useful for my research.

The Visual Novel (also known as VN) is a narrative-driven genre that originated in Japan and has steadily gained popularity in other parts of the world (Camingue, Carstensdottir and Melcer, 2021). Some of the first Visual Novels were murder mysteries and were inspired by early American adventure games, but slowly over time the puzzle-oriented design would fade out in favour of focusing more on the narrative of the games. Similarly to comics and manga, VNs also use a mix of text and visuals to convey a story, sometimes even adding animations and effects (Crimmins, 2016).

In recent years, VNs became popular medium for game designers as engines such as Ren’Py provide accessible tools for making VNs without needing a technical background. Such tools allow beginners to explore game making, while more advanced users can create more complex and engaging works (Camingue, Carstensdottir and Melcer, 2021).

Similarly to other games, VNs use a variety of archetypes to pre-establish characters to players. (Peo, 2019) To Western audience, it is more noticeable as they often use Japanese archetypes which greatly differ from what westerners know.

The specific type of Visual Novel I will be designing is called a Kinetic Novel (KNs) where there are no choices, routes or alternate endings, and it is to make the queer content be unmissable through players’ choices. It is a subset of Visual Novel genre, meaning it uses a lot same basics, such as character archetypes, but adds extra design choices such as lack of extra story routes as mentioned.

Instead of making a comic, I decided on making a KN for several reasons. For one, despite it being a Kinetic Novel (without input for player), I did originally have plans to include interactive mechanics for the player to connect to the story, akin to *Dys4ria* by Anna Anthropy (2012), but due to various constraints that was not possible. Other reasons for going with a digital medium of games, was as mentioned before animations via code, rather than specific physical construction. It allowed me to visualise moments in dialogue that felt important to show through movement. If a character is embarrassed, it will help to convey the emotion if their sprite (a static image) is shaking in place.

2. Literature Review

2.1 American cinema

Before games, some of the biggest sources of entertainment were film and television, and as a result, a certain understanding of queerness emerged from these platforms. Of course, there is a big discourse in those circles about “if movies can influence viewers’ perceptions or not”, but as stated by Koeun in Queer-coded Villains (And Why You Should Care) (2017) that: “The first place that young children come across people who look and act differently from themselves is often on a screen.” which means television can be a main source of how people view the world simply because that is what they were exposed to.

Between 1934 and 1968 there was a set of guidelines for self-censorship of content in the USA for movies, known as the Motion Picture Production Code, or the Hays Code. It came from the various scandals caused by the Hollywood movies made in the 1920s, and then “the public came to view Hollywood as an immoral and reckless entity that was promoting an

unhealthy lifestyle." (Ward, 2020) While queerness was not outright banned, there was a part of it that stated, "sexual perversion or any inference to it is forbidden," which was clearly aimed specifically at homosexuality, as it was seen as perverse.

To get around the heavy restrictions, film-makers and writers used "queer coding", "characters that are not explicitly stated as homosexual but display stereotypical behaviors and traits consistent with those of queer communities." (Koeun, 2017). Queer-coding used various hidden meanings to imply a character as homosexual without consequences due to possible deniability. In recent times, queer coding is being used to paint characters as jokes or deviants without facing backlash.

A famous film-maker, Alfred Hitchcock, was someone who used it quite often in his films. He was one of the reasons why the rule was changed, as he was the one who promoted showing any kind of queer coding in a negative light. (Ward, 2020) Ward writes that Hitchcock's 1948 movie Rope is an example of the film-maker using queer coding to vilify queerness without outright stating so. Ward (2020) describes the film as:

> This marries homosexuality and sinisterism together, a prime example of a subliminal message that being gay in itself is somehow perverse, as the killing and the suggestion of gay sex are so closely intertwined. The murder and the reasons for committing it are sinister, twisted and so psychotically sick that the viewer is left with the feeling that it had something to do with their gayness. Thereby hammering home the point that being gay is synonymous with being evil and twisted. (p. 19-20)

Around 1961, the Hays Code had a major alteration regarding homosexuality, where "if treated tastefully and not shown to be a positive or valid life choice", it allowed queer depictions. This led to major demonisation and the portrayal of queer characters as devious and evil. (Ward, 2020) This change was both a blessing and a curse, as it led to more outright appearances of queer characters, but now they were only known as untrustworthy and evil from the get-go.

Even in modern times, companies like Disney continue their discrimination of gay and queer people, such as "forcing to censor overtly gay affection in their films." (Cowling, 2024), even as they continue using queer coding on their villains. A great example would be using face of a drag queen Devine to design Ursula who is the villain of their film The Little Mermaid (Cowling, 2024).

That is not to say that people are familiar with exact queer stereotypes that often come up with media, but rather that the Hays Code has affected how queer characters are portrayed in media. Therefore, viewers may come to associate queer characters with being villains, dying, or overall being "sexually perverse" even without realising so (Ward, 2020). To further this, many may not associate 'jocks' or 'nerds' as being prevailingly masculine coded as tropes, but this particular research draws from typical depictions of this tropes that I have encountered in Western Media particularly. Whilst this may be statistically eschewed, the deeply personal stakes of this investigation are drawn largely from my active perception of the portrayal of these tropes in both my formative and later years of life.

The reason for observing Western—specifically United States—media is due to majority of game studios being located either in United States or Canada, as well as American domination of the mediascape in the last few decades. (Látal, 2022) United States has its own "self-regulatory organisation responsible for assigning age ratings for video games." says Látal, pointing that despite other countries having their own systems, a lot of them follow American ratings about "profanity, graphic violence, or sexual content [...]." (Látal, 2022)

Both the impact of the Hays Code and the American domination of the mediascape have been a great impact on how characters are portrayed as they will most often follow American trends. That is one of the reasons I chose American stereotypes of a "nerd" and a "jock" characters, as they are quite identifiable by people nowadays, even if they are not American themselves.

2.2 Queerness in games

First known positive queer representation in gaming was *Caper in the Castro* (1989) where two main characters are queer, one being a lesbian private detective and the other being a drag queen. It was developed as part of charity in hope to raise money for AIDS epidemic. (Bay Area Reporter, 1989)

Throughout the years queerness in games was played off as jokes or as villains, similarly to how cinema coded queers as villains or deranged cross-dressers. (Ward, 2020) There were some positive examples of queer characters in games, but they were usually "underground", made by queer creators, and often spread through word of mouth. One such example could be *GayBlade* (Ryan Best, 1992) which was made by a hobbyist programmer and self-distributed by Ryan to friends and acquaintances. (High Score, 2020)

> […] The vast majority of games focus on cisgender and heterosexual portrayals and stories, rendering most queer experiences invisible within the medium, the development process and player communities. Although this is changing – on the one hand, indie developers often put more focus on marginalised communities, and on the other hand, a handful of large development studios are slowly starting to incorporate queer stories into their games – queer representation is still lacking. (Kilzer, p.14, 2022)

In games with romance, there is also an interesting trend of including queerness where characters will romance the player character regardless of gender. It is called “avatar-sexual romance system” (Kilzer, 2022) as the characters will answer to romantic advances regardless of player’s gender. Thus, any queer representation can be easily avoided or written as all characters being bisexual. Many queer people feel it is a “cop-out” and a way to avoid writing well developed queer characters. (Kilzer, 2022) In their paper *Dressing Commander Shepard in pink: Queer playing in a heteronormative game culture* (2015) Krobová, Moravec and Švelch, it is stated that “Homosexuality, like heterosexuality, should be an integral and well-written part of narrative.” rather than more than often “hidden away in a corner”.

There are examples of characters that have their own sexuality that are not avatar-sexual, such as Dorian Pavus from Dragon Age: Inquisition (BioWare, 2014) who is a gay man and will only romance male player characters, or Cyberpunk 2077 (CD Projekt Red, 2020) where two of the possible romance options is a lesbian and a gay man. Not surprisingly, when an explicitly queer character appears in games, they come under large amounts of scrutiny from both straight and queer audiences.

> As such, these two comments complain about Dorian's representation for different reasons. The first comment echoes the two forum posts [...], and see Dorian as an outdated and offensive cliché. They consider BioWare's attempt to convey progressive politics as a failure, and argue for a less flamboyant representation of LGBTQ characters. The last comment illustrates the concerns of those previously mentioned: Dorian, as a gay character, is annoying to straight gamers. The latter are, therefore, unlikely to learn more about him and, by extension, LGBTQ identities. (Pelurson, 2018)

Queer gamers tend to look critically at explicitly queer characters if they are “negative” representation, as some may call Dorian, as he is seen by many as a “stereotypical” gay man. That is often due to saying that not all gay/queer people are like “that”, therefore portraying them as stereotypes is extremely harmful. As Pelurson mentions in *Mustaches, Blood Magic and Interspecies Sex: Navigating the Non-Heterosexuality of Dorian Pavus* (2018) that “[...] many of Dorian's traits — flamboyance, flirtatiousness, being overtly sexual — are perceived by some as being negative stereotypes that harm LGBTQ people.” In their article, it is pointed out that Dorian is seen as “annoying” to straight gamers and therefore they are less likely to learn more about LGBTQ identities. It becomes a problem of grinding down Dorian’s character

to just his stereotypical behaviours rather taking him in as a whole character. Pelurson argues that:

> However, Dorian should be approached as more than an example of positive gay representation. Indeed, if Dorian is not romanced by the main character, he might start a relationship with the Iron Bull, a non-human pansexual warrior. This unusual relationship redefines Dorian's sexual identity, and allows for a new queer reading of this extravagant mage. (Pelurson, 2018)

Dorian may be overall a popular character in *Dragon Age* franchise, but no one can properly agree on him. Some will say he is a damaging stereotype, while others will praise his portrayal and story. It can be both true that Dorian is a gay stereotype and that he has a good story that goes beyond just him being gay.

The reason for observing some examples of queer characters in games is showcasing direct vs indirect queerness and how people react to it. As I have observed in my life, a game with avatar-sexual characters will be praised by queer communities for representation, but more direct examples like Dorian will face backlash, as pointed out by Pelurson (2018). It is possible that many queer people want “safe” queer representation, as mentioned by Pelurson: “[…] Dorian, as a gay character, is annoying to straight gamers. The latter are, therefore, unlikely to learn more about him and, by extension, LGBTQ identities.” (2018) Queer people should be included as long as they are not in players’ ways or faces, “hidden away in a corner.” (Krobová, Moravec & Švelch, 2015), and most importantly, not “annoying”. This is important as Visual Novels with romance systems could fall under avatar-sexual representation, but using Kinetic Novels and taking that choice away from players forces them to acknowledge queer existence.

Queering games (Clark, 2017) have two major parts: one being that games for the longest time cantered around the same topics and urges designers to deconstruct pre-existing assumptions and patterns in games. This tactic shares roots with other academia, such as history, economic analyses, and many others, where ideas are often confined to a certain, unspoken norm, and upon destabilising those ideas, it opens a wide field of possibilities. The other part is "destabilising" the fundamental structure of games and seeing what can be done instead. For the longest time, game designers lived by a rigid set of rules on how to make games, but it was queer designers who toppled that belief, making many question "what makes a game?"

2.3 Tropes and stereotypes

Tropes and archetypes are often used in various media to help pre-establish certain themes. To differentiate, a trope only works within a certain genre that gives it context, while archetype is a motif that may reoccur universally. A nerd trope needs an academic setting to work, like high school, but hero archetype can be recognised without a genre.

Stereotypes and archetypes share some overlaps, yet in the end they are quite different. It comes down to that archetypes are used to make characters recognisable more quickly with traits that often follow a set pattern, while stereotypes are used to reduce groups of people into a certain set (most usually negative) of descriptors.

> An archetype is the basic character that moves a story forward, such as Prince Charming as the hero and Cinderella as the Innocent, and is applicable in multiple cultures. However, stereotypes are very culture specific. In many cultures, certain groups are seen as possessing specific, often negative, characteristics. Individuals within those groups are treated as if these negative stereotypes are true, which is seldom the case. (Kidd, 2016, p. 26)

What is important is not letting stereotypes become “mainstream”, meaning when we see characters of set minority, we will immediately assume the worst of them. A queer character

in media? They must be flamboyant and/or die by the end. Or that a character of colour is a violent criminal, or uneducated. Following the cultivation theory (Gerbner, Gross, Morgan, Signorielli, 1994) that what we see in media, especially from young age, may alter how we perceive the world, it is important to stay vigilant of what stereotypes we may see, lest we continue the cycle.

According to Arltoft and Benkö (2019): “Through the repeated use of them in creating stereotypical caricatures as opposed to proper representation, tropes themselves may have earned a negative reputation alongside stereotypes as something for the queer community to reject.” It is important to tread lightly when dealing with stereotypes and even tropes due to their misuse by media for so long.

Visual Novels often employ the similar design tactics as anime and manga, as they also come from Japan, where it is common to use archetypes in stories. VNs are heavy on usage of text and art and tend to prioritise storytelling over action, and using archetypes can be a good way to quickly convey what kind of personality a character may have. “While archetypes make a character predictable, they can also serve as a strong foundation to start off the design process.“ (Peo, 2019). It is driven by humans’ need to categorise to understand the world around them more easily, which often leads to subconscious stereotyping of others.

This is one of the reasons for using visual novel medium in this research, as it already has roots in archetyping characters. It is also much easier to make a text-based game as a solo developer, while also focusing more on the characters’ designs and personalities.

2.4 Limitations

One of the biggest limitations in this research is that it will be heavily skewed by my perspective and understanding no matter what I do. As a queer person myself, I have my own experiences which I may use in this creative work, but it may not reflect what someone else may have gone through. I am writing this work with that heavily in mind, that is why one of the core processes of this work will be performing semi-structured interviews. I will aim to have a substantial sample size to be able to compare different opinions that people hold about queer representation. Of course, I will try to ask non-queer people for interviews, but I hope the core of the responses will be from queer people.

Despite everything, art is subjective and what I think may happen may be very different from what actually happens. My own understanding of art and storytelling may not be what players are used to and therefore may not notices the nuances I put into my work despite them being quite clear to me. If a semi-passing trans character appears in the story, can the reader see the little details about them that I put in, or are they so glaring to me because I am trans myself and it is a story I am writing?

3. Methodology

Using plaited exegesis, I made a Kinetic Novel game following two queer characters who are designed using two masculine stereotypes of “Nerd” and “Jock”. Exegesis as a method is a rather unique as an approach as it becomes deeply personal for the author. It is created using external sources for information but also applying own positionality and experiences to the work (Whitcher, 2025). Plaited exegesis (also referred to as “connective exegesis”) is used to look at the established field of research to explain and illustrate the practise, rather than showcase the theory with practise (Ings, 2015). Which means, I will be using theory to support my work, rather than using my work as an example of the theory.

> [Exegesis] differs from research-driven creative models, such as research-through-design and even practice-led research, in that the reflection is concurrent with the production, not an instigation or follow-up, and is thus embedded in the very nature of the research itself. (Whitcher, 2025)

I plan on using exegesis for my work, as I think creating the game itself is the most important step, especially as the research focuses on the graphics and how the characters are presented both visually and narratively. Keeping notes and later reflecting on my own choices could lead to fascinating results on my thought processes and how they themself are impacted by society. While understanding stereotypes and archetypes is one thing, it is another to apply them properly, especially as they will be rooted in my own culture and what media I have consumed.

> An exegesis is the written text that accompanies a creative project. For that reason, it may not always follow the traditional thesis models of other disciplines. This is because "practice-led research situates creative practice as both a driver and outcome of the research process; it also positions the researcher in a unique relationship with the subject of the research" (Hamilton & Luke, 2009, p. 32). The exegesis, therefore, could be considered a new form of academic writing that adds to the diversity of thesis structure. (Charles Darwin University, n.d.)

The main point of an exegesis is to focus on the work that is being created rather than the essay itself. The writing becomes more reflective and reflexive, having the author become their biggest critic. It can be used to record the creative process, and then to analyse all of the gathered notes.

One of the main points of this work will be creative *research through design* (see Zimmerman, Forlizzi and Evenson, 2007) which will focus on making a game as part of the research process. Part of it is also *experimental game design* (Waern & Back, 2015) where the game will also become an experiment to help understand the topics in more depth. Improving upon a design is part of creating a game, but to make it part of research is to focus on a singular part of the game. Rather than focus on balancing the game and the attributes within it, the goal is to study certain aspects of it and expand upon it, even if it is not properly balanced.

I aim to use the RTD (research through design) structure of adapting the design from feedback as I work on the project alongside experimental game design framework (Clark, 2017) and plaited exegesis (Ings, 2015; Whitcher, 2025)

Everyone can easily get caught up when they are designing characters, especially when their identities are such an important part of the story. The cultivation theory (Gerbner, Gross, Morgan, Signorielli, 1994) in modern times, is applicable to games as well, not just movies. It is more common for people, especially young ones, to be playing games, so it is not surprising that their worldview may be impacted by what they see in games. Seeing more positive queer representation is important as it shows that queerness is not just suffering, but it can be other things too. That is why using Vito Russo Test (Gay and Lesbian Alliance Against Defamation, n.d.) to distinguish the quality of queer representation in movies can be useful when designing characters for games as well. It can help with making queer characters more than just their gender or sexuality. It will be helpful when designing my own characters, as well as using it to subvert expectations.

A good example of the cultivation theory would be in *Dressing Commander Shepard in pink: Queer playing in a heteronormative game culture* by Krobová, Moravec and Švelch (2015) where one of the research participants is quoted saying “The Glee series helped me in coming out [as homosexual] more than video games did, because everyone knew Glee, but only a few people knew some indie games.”

To collect data, I will be using the combined method of a semi-structured interview (Flick, 2014) and Think-Aloud Protocol (Ericsson & Simon, 1993). The Think-Aloud Protocol will be used after an encouragement for the play-tester to speak out their thoughts while they play the game. Of course, such course will most likely require specifying what they should mention, as often people are not used to speaking their thoughts and may omit what they do not perceive as relevant. Thus, the player may become influenced in what they focus on when playing the game, rather than a natural state they may have been in.

The semi-structured interview (Flick, 2014) will be held after a play session, or even without one, as the questions do not necessarily focus on the mechanics of the game. Understanding of the interviewees' perception of characters may be influenced by their game environment, but having the raw data of their perceptions without any outside stimuli may be interesting as well. Both the play sessions with the Think-Aloud Protocol and the interviews will be recorded with permission from the interviewees to be later data coded, where any possible patterns will be written down to be later analysed.

4. The work: How we got here

4.1 What is the work?

Reason for making this story a constrained story and a Kinetic Novel, ties back into games avoiding showing outright queerness. Had the romance been optional in any way or let players have various romance options (for example female romance options) it would change the entire point of the story. The two characters are meant to get together, and it is meant to be a queer gay story.

Many games use linear narrative to tell their stories and have been praised for that approach. Some describe it like an interactive film where they can progress without the stress of impacting the story with their choices.

4.2 Kinetic Novels

People enjoy Kinetic Novels for various reasons. On subreddit r/VisualNovels, a user asked why not instead read a book, and few users commented things like: "Books don't have background music. Books don't have voice acting. Most books have limited visuals a best, or more likely none at all." (ctom42, 2015). Some said that they did not enjoy choices in VNs at all, would search for a tutorial for best options, or when finished they would not replay for different endings at all.

User blind_guy23 (2015) commented on the thread: "Choices should really only exist if they suit the story the author is trying to tell but aren't required to tell a good story." Which I feel describe what I am aiming for well. This specific story is not aiming for multiple endings for the characters and giving players choices I feel would impact the narrative negatively.

While my own game lacks parts that people point out about KNs (Kinetic Novels), it still falls under the genre's umbrella due to being coded. There is input for the player to progress the story further, and it does have ability for the missing parts, like voice-over, to be added later. As audio was not something that the research focused on, it was discarded due to time limitations but could potentially add a lot of characterisation if implemented.

Making this research project as a VN follows an interesting trend in queer indie game development. As mentioned before, due to easily accessible tools, VNs are now relatively simple to make (Camingue, Carstensdottir and Melcer, 2021) and as such, queer indie has become quite fond of making VNs to tell their stories. One does not need to be the best artist to make a VNs compared to a traditional comic, and much of framing and movement can be easily coded instead of drawn. It is a way for queer people to be creative in a way they could not been before, to tell their stories without the stress of a publisher, and so their stories are uncensored and free to be what they want to be.

I chose to work in Unity engine instead of Ren'Py, which is a dedicated VN engine, after trying to learn the engine for a few days. As Ren'Py uses Python coding language, I would have to learn a new program and a new language for this project, so instead I switched over to Unity

engine after finding a long playlist of how to make a VN step-by-step in Unity by Stellar Studio (2023). It was an experiment, as I was already familiar with Unity and its coding from previous projects, but Ren'Py simply did not suit how I worked so I decided to discard that option. During the programming process, I ran into several problems but soon found out Stellar Studio offered the entirety of the Unity project on their Patreon upon subscription to their page and said, "feel free to use and change to your characters as you wish". I will not be using this game in any commercial sense, and I will strictly keep it to research/personal use.

4.3 The scope

Originally the scope was writing about twenty minutes of the game to build out the characters. Yet, as time passed and it became clear how time-consuming coding all the dialogue and interactions was, therefore only five minutes of the game with the characters was tested. The five minutes of gameplay was showcased as a "prologue" of the story, taking time to establish characters and the situation they are in, hoping to ease the player into what was happening.

4.4 Positionality: Being a queer in game design

Being a queer trans person is such a fascinating life as a creator. There are many parts of this experience people do not talk about or know about, but most jarring is that our mere existence is considered political. Queer people are a "quota" to meet, they are this magical unicorn that when they appear in media, they will be the point of discussion no matter how short the appearance is. Trans people are measured by their suffering, for their ability to pass without a notice, even though "we can always tell."

Queer people are seen as a monolith entity, who always agree and disagree on the same things; they are all the same. We are not allowed to do any wrong because the second we do; it will be reflected upon the community as a whole.

I can recall that even as a child, it was always the villains who were "flamboyant", it was wrong to be "other" in any way. To be "gay" was an insult thrown around the playground but never truly understood. As someone who was raised in a prominently catholic country, there was no way to learn because how can you learn something you do not know exists at all. It was only when I got older, I started to learn more about identity and the world. It was through meeting people from queer communities and hearing their stories that I started to understand more.

My own experience was one of the reasons for making this thesis. I wanted to learn more about queer history from recent years, how it has been impacted by Western cinema. Fascinatingly, I am depicting something many queer people mourn, that many non-queer people got to experience, which is high school romance without judgement or danger based on who they love. I chose to make this story as part of queer joy; I wanted to create a story where two gay characters could be in love without making it a hidden or easily skippable story. How different is a queer creator using stereotypes in their story to a non-queer creator? I am aiming to make it a commentary, but everyone will have their interpretation of my own work, but I know what I wanted to make with this; and it was to learn.

Due to various reasons, this research had to be greatly reduced in scale, which impacted the current result to be much smaller than originally planned. Despite the hurdles, I am happy I still managed to learn something from this study about queerness and how people view it.

When I first began this study, I was unsure of what exactly I wished to research about queer stereotypes. Having worked in queer research before, it was an area I wanted to continue working in but wished to take a creative route while doing so. Much of queerness in games, especially academia I feel like, revolves around queer suffering, be it in games, or in real world as a queer maker. I wished to explore reclaiming something for myself as a queer person and decided to explore stereotypes as a visual medium in games. As an artist, it felt well suited to

go in that direction, to focus more on the characters and their designs than the game and its mechanics.

It is important to remember that as this is an exegesis work, meaning heavily reliant on my experiences and knowledge. Therefore, when making claims it is from perspective of a transmasculine queer person and how the research may seem lacking to me. As a queer academic, it often feels like finding queer sources is like trying to find a needle in haystack, especially with how often queer people will be found discussing online or on blogs, but such sources are considered not valid.. The affordance of the exegesis, then, is a dual-mode form of documentation as expression and analysis – I inform my research, which is in turn the catalyst for analysis.

4.5 The Making

As mentioned by Ward (2020) queer-coding used to be a tool used by queer creators to tell our stories without the stress of being prosecuted. Instead, it was turned against us, used instead to code villains and killers as queers, to subtly influence people to associate those traits with queer people.

Stereotypes fall under tropes, but while tropes are only sometimes negative, all stereotypes stem from negative view of certain minority groups (Arltoft & Benkö, 2019). Tropes and archetypes differ by that tropes can only be seen in certain scenarios or cultures, while archetypes are more general and may be found across various cultures or time periods. Such example could be of a “nerd” character, where they are recognised as overly smart in science topics, but lack social skills, but require a specific circumstance to be used, ergo a trope.

In many romance Visual Novels, it is usually a teenage boy who is kind of a loser who ends up romancing various girls in his school, and who to romance is usually up to the player and their choices. To queer the narrative, I decided to change how the plot goes, and it is instead now a gay love story of a teenage boy who is trying to romance his male crush. In this, I am taking the players’ choice away, making the queer love story undeniable.

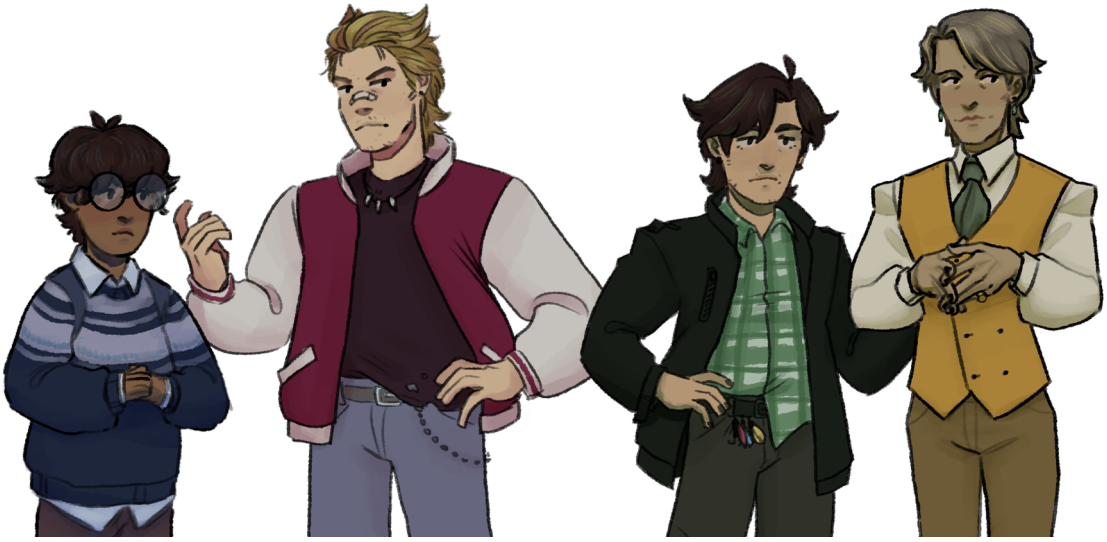


Figure 1. Original cast of the game before redesigning. From left to right: Castor, Gabriel, Viktor, Aidas. (art by the author)

In VNs characters are most often portrayed using static images called “sprites”, though they may also use 3D models or animated 2D images. For my game, I used 2D sprites with different image for each character expression. I limited the number of expressions to three per character as I thought it gave me a pretty good range in the beginning. Gabriel was given

expressions: neutral, surprised, and embarrassed; while Castor had neutral, speaking, and embarrassed.

The reasons Castor was given a “speaking” sprite instead of a surprised like Gabriel was due to characterisation. The speaking sprite is meant to showcase when he is stating relevant information in a very “nerdy” way, such as talking about scientific studies he read about distractions when studying. Taking away his “surprised” sprite was also a slight hint that he is not overly emotive like Gabriel. Even with just sprites, various characterisation can be established with how they react to situations.

While there are no “official” sources for researching stereotypes, I would often search online for articles and opinions people would have on what they perceive as a stereotype in media. Such example would be an article by Kim Leonard (2019), *Stereotypes in Movies and How Filmmakers Can Avoid Them* that briefly goes over queer stereotypes, but I would also use websites such as TVTropes for research.

One of the main characters is Gabriel, who is designed using “the Jock” trope from Western media, usually seen as a bully and “an unintelligent” character, who is also most popular boy in school. In my story, I want Gabriel to seem at first as an antagonist, a bully with a short temper, and someone many fear. To subvert the expectations, he is the one trying to win over another character, acting shy and unsure of himself when faced with his crush. He is also meant to seem excited about the play in school, subverting the usual “this is boring” mentality writers give to athletic characters. In game, Gabriel was given more animated moments alongside his sprites to showcase when he may be extremely surprised or really embarrassed and does not want to talk about something. Even when he is not the one speaking, he may change his expressions, reacting to something that was said around him. He is meant to be seen as more reactive of the two characters, tying back to his “jock” design, who are seen as more aggressive due to their involvement with sports.

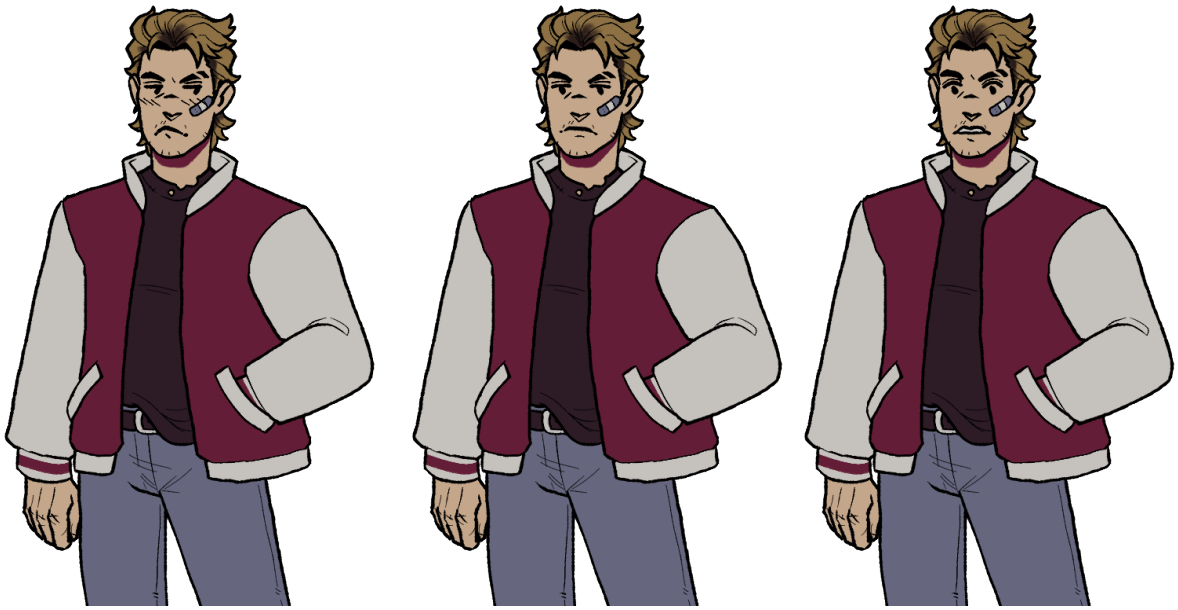


Figure 2. Gabriel’s redesign expression sheet. (art by the author)

The other main character, and Gabriel’s love interest, is Castor, who is a pre-transition man, and “the Nerd” trope character. He is meant to look shy and small, his round shapes and glasses to signal to the player his “softness”. Instead, he is not at all shy but rather speaks his mind often and is not scared of calling out others on their behaviour. So far in the game, there is not much outright reference to Castor being transgender, except for a moment where a teacher calls his deadname and he corrects her. Compared to Gabriel, he is more reserved and does not have as many emotional reactions to things around him. That does not mean he is shy or unemotional, but rather a way to showcase different personality.



Figure 3. Castor's redesign expression sheet. (art by the author)

There were two side characters that were originally designed with Castor and Gabriel. As they did not appear in the game during the testing, they did not receive redesigns and were scrapped from the project. They were meant to act as mirrors to the main characters and were posed in such a way to show it. One of the unused characters, Aidas, was made in mind as a flamboyant gay man, and something of a "gay best friend" stereotype.

There were total of 6 people interviewed, two of which presented as male, and four that presented as female. I did not ask the players to disclose if they were queer, as it would lead to a bias I felt like, as a cis person could be more read about queer history than a queer person. The questions I designed were aimed to learn more about general understanding of stereotypes in various media, and how they were recognised. Part of the interview was also asking if the players recognised any stereotypes in the characters based on their visuals, which often was answered with "yes".

After doing playtests, it was mentioned a few times that the character designs did not feel that well made when in the context of the game and their environment. Due to that feedback, I decided to slightly redesign the character art for Gabriel and Castor to lean in more to certain parts of their characters, a refresh for the art. Both had their neutral poses changed slightly, with Gabriel now appearing more casual with one hand in his jacket pocket, bleached hair to showcase his "performance" he was putting on as a tough jock, and plasters on his face to show he gets hurt often. Castor was made to look bit older while keeping him still short (a trait often associated with trans men).

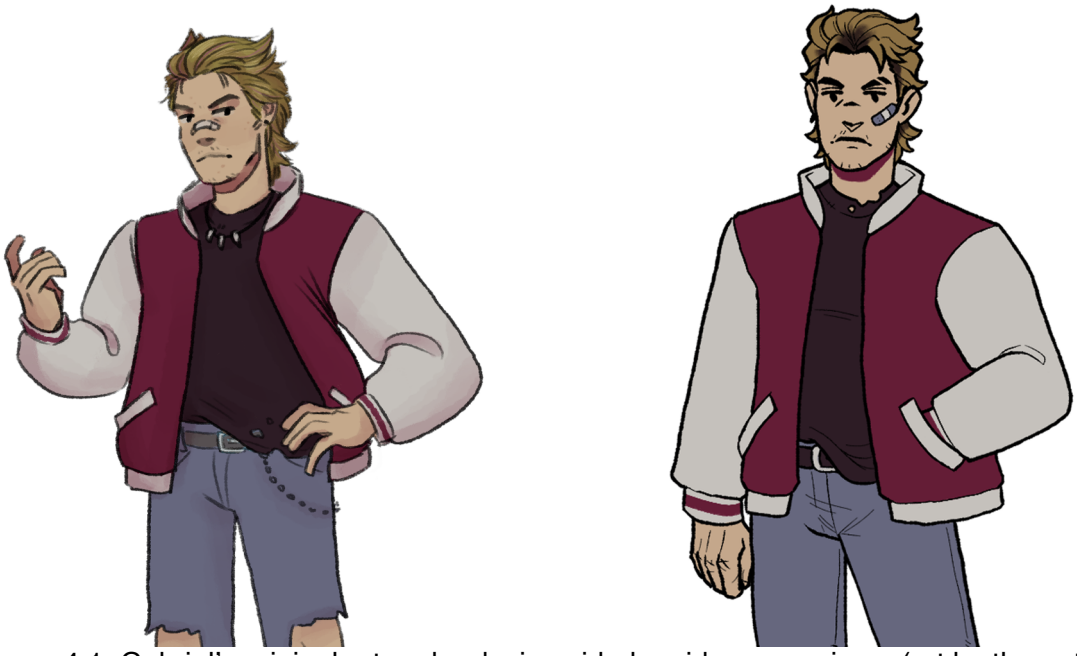


Figure 4.1. Gabriel's original art and redesign side-by-side comparison. (art by the author)



Figure 4.2. Castor's original art and redesign side-by-side comparison. (art by the author)

When concepting these two characters, I kept in mind what my own idea of these two tropes would look like, and I tried to incorporate that into their designs.

5. Reflection

Preamble

Originally, this research was meant as an exploration of recent queer history in media, and how to possibly reclaim queer stereotypes. There is much research on the topic of queer stereotypes in media such as film (Ward, 2020) but I could not find much discussion on the topic of how it has impacted storytelling in modern times, especially games, but it does not mean it does not exist. It is more typical to hear about how gender stereotypes affect public's perception of male and female roles, and how it has continued in modern times. Especially with games still sexualising women and making great profit from it.

To make a plaited exegesis (Ings, 2015; Whitcher, 2025) was an interesting experience as even in game design studies, it is more common to practise theory-based research rather than creative. Practise-based research is still in its infancy and is not as well regarded as theory-based and often does not receive as much support. Our supervisors are learning from them as much as we are. Especially with an exegesis, the results are not meant to be "definitive", the process is the research, but often we are still pressed for a "yes or no" answer.

5.1 The findings

As mentioned before, the interviews were done using semi-structured approach (Flick, 2014) and Think-Aloud Protocol (Ericsson & Simon, 1993). This allowed for a more or less open discussion with participants about the game and the research. Think-Aloud Protocol and recording it, allowed for me to come back to it later and listen for anything interesting I may have missed during the initial playtest, such as various comments about the characters or the dialogue. Interestingly, the interviews varied greatly in length from about eight minutes to over half an hour, so it was hard to establish how long one interview would take.

During the interviews, many of the interviewees could name the tropes the main two characters were, just by their character designs. During one of the playtests, a player mentioned Castor looked much younger than Gabriel, which led me to slightly altering their designs and looking more into what people on the internet considered "the nerd" and "the jock". That was somewhere in the middle of the process, and I tried to keep the core of their character designs while adjusting it more to the setting.

It felt daunting to write this story and characters, for even as a queer person, a lot of the experiences mentioned in the story have never happened to me. I have never done a play in school, which prompted me to research extensively on when, how, who, how long, and so on. I happen to be an aromantic, therefore I do not experience attraction the same way as other queer people, so I was stressing I was not portraying Gabriel's attraction in an accurate way. I feel like that fear was bit founded, as one of the interviewees thought that Gabriel was interested in cheerleaders mentioned by Castor instead of him. That does beg the question, is that because they were straight themselves, because of how media portrays these stories, or something else?





Figure 5.1 and 5.2. Scenes from the game where Gabriel becomes flustered about asking Castor for help. (art by the author. Background public domain)

Yet, as expected, there were no mentions of any queer stereotypes that could be attributed to the main characters. This was entirely my fault in how I designed the characters. They were designed with my perspective as a queer person; therefore, they were clearly gay to me, but it may not have come across as such to an outside perspective.

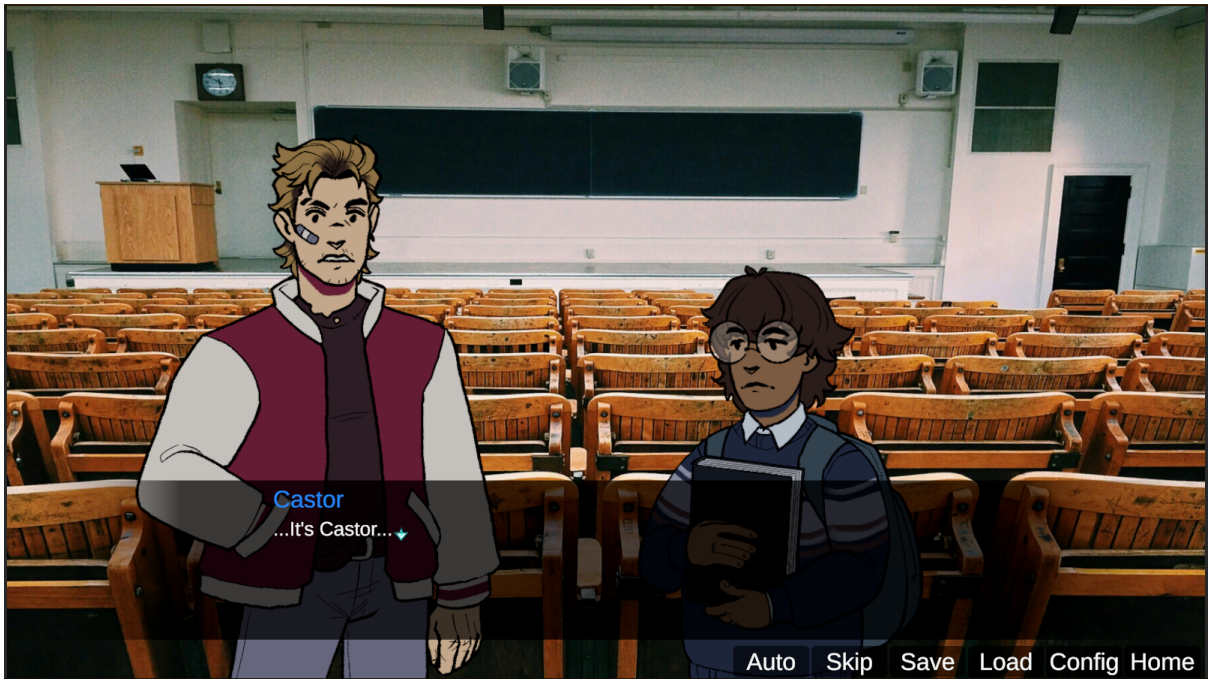


Figure 6. Scene from the game where Castor gets dead named. (art by the author. Background public domain)

With that in mind, it came as a surprise when in game, when Castor is clearly deadnamed (using trans person's birth name instead of their preferred name) one of the players entirely missed the point and simply thought it was a misspelling mistake. As most of my interviewees were cis (a person who identifies their gender with their sex assigned at birth), this may have impacted their view of what was happening. Especially as a trans person, my own experience is that of being overly aware of how other people perceive me, but most cis people do not have to worry about it (with exception of people who identify as women). Therefore, a simple name mix up may not seem as significant to them as it does to trans people.

Most of the interviewees decided they would prefer to have queer creators make queer games. The consensus was that non-queer developers should aim to get help from queer people when writing their games if they do. It was not explained by anyone how they would view it, should the author disclose they are queer? Are they allowed to only make queer games? I feel like it should be possible for non-queer people to make queer games and characters as well, for it opens the world of possibilities, yet they should keep in mind asking for advice from queer people and reflecting on what they are doing.

Though, not all queer people are required to give you advice on their lives, there are people who specialise in that, so you should not just grab a random queer people off of the street and ask them their opinions on your queer character. Some find it a deeply personal experience, plus there are many places where being openly queer is simply not safe.

There have been many situations of queer indie creators being doxxed by people online, simply for making queer games. A queer game is only acceptable when it is mainstream, but even then, it is not guaranteed (Mejeur, 2020).

Interestingly, few people commented that when a queer character appears in media, they fear they will end up as "bury your gays" trope or something as bad, which most likely also connects to queer-coding villains. It has been slowly changing with times, but it is still a valid fear to have, especially now with sudden wave of queer hate that has been raising in United States.

While I was strongly advised to perhaps work on journaling alongside my work, it did not suit my creative processes. Due to some physical restrictions, writing my thoughts down has never worked well for me, as I tend to create intricate webs of thought in my head that come together

to create character designs. While I understand it could have been helpful to break down my process, it did not seem as suited for me. A possible proposal would be for anyone who wishes to do similar work to perhaps make audio journals, maybe even add presentations for visuals. It could be an interesting work where the entire research is done through usage of video recordings.

This work used Visual Novels as a medium, but it would be possible to use other approaches for similar research, such as comics, animations, or similar visual mediums. It is important to keep it within the genre of visual medium due to such important part of visual character design. Two people could imagine the same character differently if their only description is written down rather than a picture.

5.2 Reflection and further research

Queering the game (Clark, 2017) was part of this research and I feel like I both failed and succeeded in various parts. While it does not include any kind of novel new idea that breaks the mould of the genre, I still think that this as creative research brings something new to the field.

Research through design (Zimmerman, Forlizzi and Evenson, 2007) I fear did not have as much impact on this research as I wished it did. It was still kept in mind throughout the process, such as changing the designs upon feedback from playtesters. Had the game been longer, I feel like it would have worked better, alongside the various mechanics I wished to implement. It is something to keep in mind if the research was to be continued at another time in the future.

All my research goals were met in some way and could potentially lead to further research. While there is so much more to learn about the impact of portrayal of queer characters in media through various years, the current research in this paper feels like a compact introduction to the topic. Originally, the story was meant to include a murder mystery, which I feel like could have greatly played with the “bury your gays” trope and subverting expectations, as well as queer coding villains.

With designing the characters as queer stereotypes, it would appear it as only partially successful due to my own understandings of what the characters should look like. Neither of the two characters are villains, and they are more subtly queer. They do great presenting their non-queer tropes of “the jock” and “the nerd” though, meaning I was successful in that part. Same with subverting players’ expectations of the characters’ personalities. Interviewees were pleasantly surprised when they noticed the characters acting differently than they assumed they would.

To bring back the main question of this research: How do stereotype visuals influence how we see queer characters, and where do they come from?

I feel like I have learned much about queer history in media, especially how queer coding was originally used by queer people to get around the Hays Code and was later twisted against us. Understandably, the interviews shined a bit of understanding on how people perceive characters through their designs and actions. We can be introduced to a character and their personality entirely just by how they are first presented when they appear in a story, what they do, even without them saying a word. Yet, the second they open their mouth, these perceptions can be entirely shattered by how they sound or even say.

Gabriel was introduced as a violent individual who often gets in trouble with the school, and the moment he is around Castor, he becomes shy and unsure of himself.

Castor looks like someone who studies a lot and may appear shy, often said characters with glasses hide behind them, but he is blunt and is not scared of Gabriel when he speaks to him.

My goal was to learn, create, and to see how it would all turn out; despite everything, I am pleased with the results that came from this study.

6. Conclusion

When I began this research, I only had a glancing idea of queer stereotypes and tropes, from my own consumption of various media and experiences. I never expected the amount of information I would stumble upon while researching or learning about the Hays Code.

There is so much I have learned about the history of queerness in media and so much more that could be learned. The time between 2000s and 2010s seem so shrouded in mystery of what was going on in queer gaming until the queer indie boom in 2010s. There are only mentions of mainstream games using queer stereotypes in negative light, or no mention of queers at all. It could be fascinating research, to speak with queer developers who were active during that time, to find out more.

Queerness and being open about it has been a really important part of figuring out my life. To many, queer representation seems like just “checking off a list”, having to include it because everyone has to nowadays. To queer people, it is more than that; it could allow young queers to learn more about themselves, to see they are not alone, to see themselves in different roles, see how different queer people can be. To see that it is not just villains who are queer. To see our stories have as much weight as those of straight and cis people.

Yet, the queer stories may not be seen as well by straight and cis people, as they do not understand the same struggles, pains, joys, and hopes as we experience. Their view will be warped by their own lenses, but so may our own. Even as queer people we are not exempt from fault, it does not make us perfect, it just gives us a different perspective.

Art is an amazing tool for expression; it allows us to channel ourselves and our experiences unto various canvases, such as painting, making games, making music, and many more.

Making this game was an amazing experience of exploring the queerness of both the characters, but also my own and how I perceive it.

There is much more that could be done with this research that could be found. I would like to continue working on this VN and the characters, perhaps for research, or just to explore queer stories and designs on my own. At one point, this research also included a look into fandom and fan culture that I feel like are important parts of queer experience in media by fans. Perhaps with extra time, I could have a look at how it could tie in into queer making and queering games.

The plaited exegesis works well for creative research to reflect on your own work and examine your thought processes, and to inject the author’s voice into the research. It would work well for more game design based research as much of game making relies on our own knowledge and experiences.

There is much that could be said about this work, but most important is that queer people will live on in any way we can and we will thrive. No work can be perfect for everyone for then it would make the world a boring place, there must be a place for works that make people uncomfortable.

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Appendices

Appendix 1. Game dialogue code

Narrator "Early winter, some of the warmth from the autumn still lingered in air, making the ever so shorter days bit more bearable. {c}The big musicals season had just ended, giving way to the smaller productions that would soon take place in the drama club."

"Despite the pleasant days, the atmosphere in the school has been uneasy. Something was brewing in the air and it put everyone on edge."

SetLayerMedia(background school_classroom)

CreateCharacter(Gabriel), Gabriel.Show()

CreateCharacter(Teacher)

"...And those with short tempers did not fare that well, to no one's surprise."

Gabriel as ??? "What do you mean I have to join?! Won't that hit my grades even worse?!"

Teacher "*Sigh*, luckily, no. You will receive extra points for participating in extracurricular activities- And before you mention sports, you have been suspended from participating until we have seen improvement in behaviour. {c} I have already spoken to your teachers, with addition to you joining a less... dynamic activity, we also urge you to find someone to help with your academic work. {c}If you prefer we do have a student in mind."

Gabriel as ??? "All of this just for kicking in some little bitch's nose-"

Teacher "Gabriel! Enough. {c}I know that Mr Shaun has had... less than stellar behaviour but it did not warrant sending him to the hospital."

Gabriel "Fine. I will try to find some nerd to help me with homework *and* join this dumb winter play."

Teacher "Splendid! I hope I do not have to see you in my office for at least a month, Gabriel."

Gabriel.Hide()

Gabriel "Yeah, yeah, whatever."

wait(1)

ClearLayerMedia(background)

Narrator "Some time later..."

SetLayerMedia(background school_lockers)

CreateCharacter(Castor), Castor.SetPosition(0.2), Castor.Show()

Castor as ??? "And you want me to...?"

Gabriel.SetPosition(0.7), Gabriel.Show()

Gabriel "Help me with school work."

Castor as ??? "How long? You are being very unclear, is it just some classes or all of them, because I am not that good with English Literature or History so I do not know how-"

Gabriel "Mostly the science subjects. Principal said if I don't get my grades up I may not get to play the coming season, and I know you have the best grades in our year. {c} I can deal with the Lit and History, please Cas?"

Castor "*Sigh*, It's Castor, but okay, I will help you.{wa 1} Though I don't get why it has to be me. The cheerleaders have just as good grades as me, and I imagine they would be way more happy to work with you."

Gabriel.SetSprite(Bashful -l -spd 1)

Gabriel ".{wa 0.5}.{wa 0.5}.{wa 0.5}Just help me pass the year."

Castor "I already said I will. I do not get why I need to repeat myself."

Gabriel.SetSprite(Default -l -spd 1)

Gabriel "Whatever. So how do you want to go about it? I come over to your place and you help me with homework?"

Castor "No."

Gabriel "...No?"

Castor.SetSprite(Speaking -l -spd 1)

Castor "No. {c}We will meet after classes at the library and we will study there. Studies have shown that separating personal and working spaces greatly helps focus and productivity."

Gabriel "Fine. After classes at the library then."

Castor.SetSprite(Default -l -spd 1)

Gabriel.Hide(), Castor.Hide()

ClearLayerMedia(background)

Narrator "Few days later..."

SetLayerMedia(background school_drama)

Gabriel.SetPosition(0.2),Gabriel.FaceRight(-i), Gabriel.Show()

Gabriel "*I can't believe I am going to be losing so many of my afternoons now to this.*"

Gabriel "*Eh, it could have been worse...*"

Gabriel.SetSprite(Surprise -l -spd 1)

Gabriel "*-?!*"

Castor.SetPosition(0.7), Castor.FaceRight(), Gabriel.Animate(Shiver true), Castor.Show()

Gabriel "And what are *you* doing here ?!!"

Castor "Why are you yelling?"

Gabriel.Animate(Shiver false)

Gabriel.SetSprite(Default -l -spd 1)

Gabriel "I just never thought theatre would be your scene...{c} You seem the nerdy type for space and all that shit."

Castor "It's called astronomy, and I do really love it."

Castor.SetSprite(Bashful -l -spd 1)

Castor ".{wa 0.5}.{wa 0.5}.{wa 1.5}My brother made me come, he said it could be fun, and if I didn't like it I could leave whenever I wanted."

Gabriel "...I'll have to thank him when I see him next then..."

Castor "What?"

Castor.SetSprite(Default -l -spd 1)

Gabriel.SetSprite(Bashful -l -spd 1)

Gabriel "Uh, so you don't spend that much time home if you are doing all these extracurriculars?"

Castor "Why are you asking me this? Usually jocks like you just ignore my existance."

Gabriel "...{c}I mean, we *are* going to be spending extra time together, so may as well get to know each other?"

Castor "Well, no.{c} I am not really helping you as a friend, I am doing it because you asked for help. I see no point in befriending you as soon as the deal is over you will go back to ignoring me."

Gabriel.SetSprite(Surprise -l -spd 1)

Gabriel "Hey, that's-"

Teacher "Ah! Everyone, welcome! As you know, it's time for the seasonal play where anyone in school can join. I can already see a lot of new faces joining us..."

Castor.Hide(), Gabriel.Hide(), Gabriel.SetSprite(Default -l -spd 1)

ClearLayerMedia(background)

Narrator "An hour later..."

SetLayerMedia(background school_drama)

Gabriel.SetPosition(0.2), Gabriel.Show(), Castor.SetPosition(0.7), Castor.Show()

Gabriel "Y'know who you wanna try for?"

Castor "...{wa 0.5}We don't even know what the play will be yet."

Gabriel.Animate(Shiver true), Gabriel.SetSprite(Bashful -l -spd 1)

Gabriel "R-Right, but like, main character, a tech, or something..."

Castor "Probably someone who doesn't have to speak too much... I promised Viktor I would at least *try* to get an acting role..."

Gabriel.Animate(Shiver false)

Gabriel "Uh-huh.{wa 0.5}.{wa 0.5}.{wa 0.5} But still a character?"

Castor "Yes.{c} And from how intensly you were looking at the test script, I imagine you want to play one of the main roles."

Gabriel "U-uh wh-what? N-no..."

Teacher "Do we have a... Alice?"

Gabriel.SetSprite(Surprise -l -spd 1)

Castor "...{wa 0.5}It's Castor..."

Teacher "I am so sorry sweetie! It seems the office is still making the mix up."

Castor "Sure... {wa 0.2}Can I just do the scene?"

Gabriel.SetSprite(Default -l -spd 1)

Teacher "Of course, the scene is yours, Castor!"

Castor.Hide(), Gabriel.Hide()

ClearLayerMedia(background)

Load(Chapt1)

Appendix 2. Interview questions

1. What kind of media do you enjoy the most? Movies, books, games, comics?
2. Do you mostly enjoy Western or Eastern media? Or a mix?
3. When they happen, do you ever notice when a stereotype or a trope happens in media you are consuming?
4. How do you feel about them when you see them?
5. What are some common tropes/stereotypes you can think of?
6. Can you connect any tropes/stereotypes to the characters in the game?
7. Do you think all stereotypes/tropes are negative?
8. How do you approach queer characters when they appear in media?
9. Do you prefer when a queer developer writes queer characters or if a non-queer developer writes them? Or is there no difference?